



Invasion of France
Paratroopers of the 439th Troop Carrier Group aboard a Douglas C-47 just before taking off from an airbase in England. Secondary parachutes and life vests were worn in case of emergencies *(far left)*.

none the less slated to seize and hold vital objectives inland from the invasion beaches. For the majority of paratroopers, who had not been in Sicily or Italy, D-Day was their first real experience of combat after two years of training. Since the drop was to take place in pitch darkness, they were issued with "clickers" to emit a sound that would hopefully allow them to find one another once on the ground, and with a password so they would not kill one another. Hyping themselves up for the operation, some shaved their heads and daubed their faces with war paint.

NORMANDY

An armada of transport aircraft and towed gliders lifted the airborne divisions off from British airfields on the night of 5-6 June, but chaos ensued on arriving over the French coast. Confused by fog and dodging heavy flak, the aircraft dropped their parachutists over a wide area. Many men lost their equipment. Some drowned, landing in the sea or in marshland. It was a remarkable tribute to the quality of US airborne training that mostly unblooded troops, fighting with limited arms and in scattered units, succeeded as well as they did, spreading confusion behind German lines, seizing key gun emplacements, bridges, and causeways, and helping hold off German counterattacks against the US forces on Utah beach. Airborne soldiers remained in the thick of the fighting in Normandy for between three and five weeks, taking substantial casualties.



Garrison cap badge
The garrison cap bore a badge showing a white parachute against blue infantry piping.

WAR TO THE END

After Normandy, the faith of Allied commanders in airborne operations was at its peak. This led to the immense gamble on Operation Market Garden in September 1944. Some 33,970 US, British, and Polish airborne troops, formed into First Airborne Allied Army, were to seize a series of bridges over the Maas, Waal, and Rhine rivers in the German-occupied Netherlands, and hold them until an armoured column arrived. The 82nd and 101st Airborne were again the US divisions selected. The US troops achieved their objectives and fought off numerous German counterattacks, but the British only took one end of the Rhine bridge and overall the operation achieved little of value. Due some rest after superhuman efforts, 82nd and 101st Airborne then found themselves engaged in resisting a desperate German winter offensive in the Battle of the Bulge from December 1944 to January 1945. The 101st especially distinguished itself in the defence of Bastogne. This battle also brought 17th Airborne into action for the first time, and this relatively fresh division went on to take part in the last major air assault of the war, east of the Rhine in March 1945, the most wholly successful of the Allies' parachute and glider operations.

Washing equipment
Standard-issue washing equipment included a safety razor and blades, acid-neutralizing tooth powder and brushless shaving soap.



DISTINGUISHED SERVICE

Overall, World War II revealed the limitations of the concept of large-scale airborne operations. Parachute troops were extremely vulnerable to ground fire while floating down to earth. Large numbers of gliders were lost to accidents or anti-aircraft fire. Less than perfect weather and enemy fire often meant that men landed dispersed and far from their objectives. Surviving without heavy equipment in the face of counterattacks was costly. In short, parachuting had a limited future. But as elite light infantry, the Airborne Divisions had performed outstandingly. The 101st and 82nd had sustained more than 16,000 casualties, including 3,400 killed in action. A tradition had been established that could not be easily discarded. The 82nd Airborne was not demobilized at the end of the war and 101st Airborne was reactivated in 1954. Both remain elite forces within the US Army, although mass combat drops are no longer part of their tactics.



Heavy load
Paratroopers of the 82nd Airborne Division prepare to jump during the invasion of Normandy, on 6 June, 1944. Their heavy loads included a reserve parachute and leg bags stuffed with kit.